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Benny Powell

Trombonist Benny Powell was born in New Orleans on March 1, 1930. He was playing professionally in his teens and joined the Lionel Hampton Band in 1948. In 1951 he joined the Count Basie Orchestra and quickly began sharing the trombone solo chores with section mate Henry Coker. Benny stayed with the Basie band for twelve years, winning the Down Beat *Critic's Poll in 1956 and recording frequently with small groups during this period. In the 60s he led his own combos, played with the Merv Griffin Show band, helped administrate the Jazzmobile and continued big band work with Thad Jones and Mel Lewis. He spent much of the 70s in Los Angeles, where he performed with Bill Berry and Bill Holman. Benny currently lives in New York and tours with the jazz ensemble led by Randy Weston.*

Benny was interviewed by Michael Woods in New York City on July 27, 1995.

MW: We are filming today a jazz interview for the Hamilton College Archives, and we are here with Benny Powell, one of the great jazz trombone players. Pleasure to have you.

BP: Thank you very much. Here in New York City.

MW: We want to ask you some things about jazz, about some things maybe that young people don't know today, and see if you can fill us in and tell us some things in your career that guided you along the way, and some aspects, I also want to talk about some aspects of oral culture. How old were you when you first started playing?

BP: I played drums in grammar school, along with Vernel Fournier, who is with Ahmad Jamal's group. I imagine I was about eight or nine when I first started playing drums. And this was just little parade drums.

MW: What attracted you to the music? What drew you into a musical career?

BP: I was born in New Orleans, so that made it easy. Music was everywhere. And New Orleans has been, is and has been a tourist city, so in tourist cities there is much more employment for musicians. So there were a lot of musicians there, and there still are because it still is a place of employment. But music was sort of something you did. Everybody in the block had an instrument. It wasn't that much — well there were many after school programs. Dance was one, and music certainly was another, and sports. But music fit in with all of that because the bands, well not the grammar school bands, all we played for was commencement exercises. And I had an odd experience maybe about two years ago. After I played little parade drums in grammar school, when I went to high school, I played the bass drum. And I remember one of the pieces we played was "Poet and Peasant." This was at Booker T. Washington High School. Maybe two years ago, 50 years later after I played "Poet and Peasant," I played, as part of the New Orleans Festival, I played a performance at my high school. And I was telling the audience that it

seemed in my mind that it had taken me 50 years to get from the space back sort of behind stage, to up front. The last time I was there I was in the background playing my little bass drum now here, it's sort of achieved a little status tonight. It was great for me, you know, everybody wants to look good in their home town. So that happened to me. Actually, to answer your first question, I started playing when I was about eight years old. I played parade drums. I went to high school and played a bass drum. At about twelve, because I know I'll anticipate the next question, when did I start playing trombone, because I'm a trombonist, at about twelve, I was at an uncle's house. And as curious as kids are, I was no different. You know how kids lean backwards on a sofa and you can see what's behind it? Because all kids do that. Anyway, I saw this trombone case behind the sofa. So I inquired as to what it was and my uncle told me it was a trombone he had bought for one of his sons, who later decided that he wanted to play sports and not trombone. So I showed an interest in it. So he took it out and let me see it. Then he asked me if I would like to take it home, or take lessons, and I said yes. And I did. And I studied with a trombonist named Eddie Pearson. He's only on a couple of records in New Orleans, but a very fine trombonist. He played in the idiom of Trummy Young and that kind of style, very lyrical. Anyway I was very fortunate to have — hey I just noticed that I'm going to blend into this with [inaudible] green — it's not funny being green. Anyway, I guess I should wait for your questions, but if you don't mind I'll just tell you.

MW: No, no, this is marvelous. This is marvelous.

BP: I'll tell you my little story. I played, I studied trombone. At about age 14 someone was needed on Christmas night. They needed a musician to play at the USO during, this was during World War II. Now this is 1944, so you know most of the good musicians are in the Army. Anyway, what they needed was a warm body in the USO band I guess, and I guess word got around that I could read. So I went to play this job. And it was a bunch of older guys. But I was always an egghead. I guess you find most musicians didn't really fool around with too many toys and stuff, if you discovered music that is. What did I say that for? I lost my thought. Anyway I was a kind of a serious guy and, oh, I know, I studied, well, so by the time I was 14 I could read pretty well, because I had taken lessons. But they didn't expect me to really do too much other than be a 14-year-old kid. But there was a solo, we played stock arrangements, and there was a solo in the stock arrangements. This one was by Tommy Dorsey. And I think the title of the tune was "Ciribiribin." At any rate, there was a written solo, and before we played it, one of the musicians said, "Do you think you can handle it, kid?" And I said, "Yes, I think I can." Anyway, I put my face in the music like I was reading it. I had memorized this Tommy Dorsey solo. And they were impressed with that. They thought, wow, he sure played

good. So that sort of began my career. I can remember my career beginning in 1954 at this US show. I'm sorry, now what would that be, 1944, at this USO.

MW: You know it's funny sometimes how fate lends you that break you need.

BP: Oh, always does. Hindsight. Well I guess this is a bit away from our thought, but in Duke Ellington's book, I love the opening of the book because I can't remember, I can't quote it verbatim, but he said when he first went out his house down the driveway and got to the fence when it was time to go out, there was always someone there to tell him which way to go if he wanted to go somewhere. And that's happened throughout his career. He said whenever he needed something — but I guess it's our own awareness that does it, anyway. You know if you are aware, something tells you and you are aware of it. If not, they tell you but you're not aware of it so it doesn't do you much good.

MW: Some people say that if you really prepare and you're really good at what you do your chance will come.

BP: I think a bit of that with a bit of plain common sense too, realizing, well I know a lot of musicians believe that. So they think it's not really necessary for them to know business, know how to read contracts, know how to go and get a job, because if it's good it will come. But I say perhaps it will help you to stay in a position after you get there. But just being good, I've seen too many real good people not go anywhere because they didn't have the whole picture together. Most of the guys who are successful are pretty good businessmen, pretty good talkers and they have other talents other than their playing, what they play.

MW: In other words they understand the industry. They understand marketing.

BP: Yes. Most of all they understand humankind. They understand people. So whoever you're talking to, whether you be president or a porter, they're still made of the same thing. He's got two eyes, two ears, and stuff you know. And I think that's sort of the commonality jazz musicians make among people. Because we meet so many people, and so I think we're a little more experienced than the average person too. So when we meet somebody, we're involved right away. We see a lot about that person.

MW: Now let me come in on that. You talk about this spiritual aspect of it. Do you have a church background at all and does that figure in to your music?

BP: Oh, yeah. I mean I don't think you can be a musician and not have some kind of religious philosophy. If you're going to be a creator, you certainly must think of being created, so if you were created, there is something that created you, somebody, so anyway it teaches you that there's a higher power. So I think musicians just put two and two together like that. And we can't all verbalize exactly what we believe in and stuff, and I'm from New Orleans, and I think I'm pretty spiritual. I know that some things — I know now that some things can't be explained. Everything doesn't have to be explained. So some things

just are, and we just beat our heads against the wall. I'll tell you a for instance — maybe about seven years ago I went to Morocco with Randy Weston. I've been playing with Randy Weston for about the last 15 years, and it's really been glorious what I've been through. At any rate, this was an affiliation between French, Spanish and English. That's the way it was supposed to come out. It was the story of Randy Weston first going to Tangiers, I think maybe 25 years ago. He did go to, I don't know how much you know about Randy Weston, but he was a man born in Brooklyn and oh, maybe about twenty-five years ago his father told him that he was an African who just happened to be born in America. And you know, we've all come around and now we're all African Americans. But his father hipped him to that a long time ago. Anyway he's lived in Africa and played with African musicians. We played Montreal two weeks ago with some people called The Gnawa. Anyway, getting back to my first story, when I went to Tangier, the people we worked with are called the Gnawa, as I said. They used to be the king's orchestra, when there still was a king, that was before 1948, when Morocco got its independence or whatever, from under the protectorate. The king gave this band a whole city outside of Tangier. It's called Joujouka. It had a little prominence during I think one of the Rolling Stones, Brian Smith went there and stuff, Ornette Coleman had a little experience there. Anyway, when we were filming Randy's return to Morocco, it was really interesting because we had this town, Joujouka is about a two hour drive outside of Tangier. And somehow, Randy had gone there during his visit or something. Anyway they were taping a night there. So we got there maybe about five o'clock. And this is kind of so remote, until the cars couldn't drive up the hill. We had to ride up the hill on donkeys. And that was really very interesting because here is six jazz musicians on donkeys, you know. Already, that's ingredients for a lot of comedy. Al Harewood was the drummer. And Al has short legs so kept somehow missing the donkey. He'd get on the donkey and his legs weren't enough to grip, so he'd fall. Anyway he finally got himself situated on the donkey, and these donkeys I think for years have been trained to go straight up the hill and stuff. Anyway, this particular day, Al's donkey decided he didn't want to go up the hill. So he veers a little to the right and Al is saying, "Somebody come and give this donkey something." Anyway, we finally get up the hill, and the camera crew is setting up stuff, and it was like in this little village with trees and stuff. So they wrapped some of the equipment around trees. You know how it is when you're going to do a video shoot, the wires have to go everywhere. Anyway it just so happened that Randy had his daughter with him at that time. And just before we were about to tape, one of the branches on the trees broke. So there was a lot of conversation about the spirits didn't like something that was going on at this particular place. But it was just one of the adventures. It was pretty wild because it is the place where the whirling dervishes are kept from people, whirl

themselves into a trance, and all sorts of, that's why I said some things can't be explained. Some things are like coincidence and so forth.

MW: You know you mentioned another element along with the sense of spirituality that I think is a part of jazz, you mentioned humor.

BP: Humor?

MW: Yes.

BP: Oh, yeah, it's a vital part. I think it's a vital part to life for me. And it seems like, well I don't know, maybe birds of a feather are drawn together. It seems like most jazz musicians do have terrific senses of humor. I know in Basie's band it was one big laugh for 12 years. You know, everybody was a comedian, and some really unique humor, because it was unique personalities you know. Basie's band was very interesting.

MW: I was going to ask you about the Basie band.

BP: I joined his band when I was 21. I'll tell you the essence of my experience with Basie. I don't know if it's the essence but it's certainly the beginning. I was at the Apollo Theater working for a week in Joe Thomas' band. Also in the band was Charlie Fowlkes, who had been with Basie. Basie was on a hiatus and he was about to form another band. So Charlie Fowlkes told me where the rehearsal was going to be, and invited me to the rehearsal. So I went, and it was nice. Pretty uneventful. I can't remember, you know, I don't think — at this particular time there were a couple of jobs I wanted. The job with Charlie Ventura. Bennie Green had been there and he was about to leave, so I really wanted a small situation to play in. Then I was waiting to hear from Illinois Jacquet also. In the meantime, the Basie thing comes up, I make the rehearsal and that's fine. Charlie Fowlkes tells me when the next rehearsal is. And I come back and I make that also. I don't know how many rehearsals we did, but pretty soon we started working, and the first date I played with Basie was October 31 I think, 1951. So I think at this time we would go out of town for maybe one night or two nights a weekend, and come back in town. Well this went on for just a little while, a couple of weeks. In the meantime, from Basie I'm trying to find out if I'm hired, if I have a job or shall I tell Illinois Jacquet that, you know, no. But there was a strange quirk about Basie. If he had something that you wanted, he would sort of play a cat and mouse with you, you know, dangle it in front of you. Anyway, he knew I wanted him to say yes, Benny, you're hired. So the first time I, well you know I was sort of in awe of him anyway. I think I was all of 21 and he was the world famous Count Basie, so I would sort of find myself next to him by my own design, and I would say, "Well, Mr. Basie, how do you like the trombone section?" He'd say, "It sounds all right." And that's all I got out of that conversation. So maybe the next weekend I got brave enough to say, "Well Mr. Basie, are you satisfied with the trombones?" He said, "Yeah, it sounds pretty good." That's all I got out of that one. Next

time I went to him, I can't remember, each time I would disguise it. But finally I said, "Mr. Basie, what I'm trying to find out is, you know, am I hired? Am I with the band?" He said, "You're here aren't you kid?" And every time after that for about four or five times, that's what I'd get. "You're here aren't you, kid?" So finally I stopped asking him. And during the 12 years, I don't think he ever said yes, Benny, you've got a job. You're hired. But he was a wonderful man. I loved him. I was always in awe of older musicians. My dad died when I was seven, and I didn't have any big brothers or uncles. So the jazz musicians — Lester Young became my uncle. Illinois Jacquet and Dizzy Gillespie and Charlie Parker. I have some funny stories about the bebop thing. I'm a bebop baby. Although I was born in New Orleans, it was the beginning of the 1940's when I was ten or eleven and so forth that bebop started. So I was deeply interested in bebop, so much so that I wanted to really, and they had all sorts of things, they wore berets and horn rimmed glasses—

MW: It was part of the music.

BP: No it was a culture. Yeah it was, it was a whole lifestyle. So anyway I saw these horn rimmed glasses, so I had to have a pair of horn rimmed glasses. So I started squinting around and bumping into things and so forth. But my mother, she was hip to what I was doing, but she finally broke down and bought me some horn rimmed glasses. So I expected to put on my horn rimmed glasses and come out and everybody'd say wow, look at that bebop musician. Unfortunately, there was a character in the news funnies. We were at war with Japan. His name was Mr. Tojo. Mr. Tojo also wore horn rimmed glasses. So when I came out expecting to be called Charlie Parker, "Oh, look at Mr. Tojo." I was crushed. But that was, I went through the whole bit, man, you know, I guess that's why I have a beard today because those guys had beards. I really like that whole, well, you were speaking of a sense of humor. That's what I loved about the beboppers so much. Dizzy Gillespie was exactly that. He was nuts.

MW: He was a champion prankster.

BP: Oh, yeah. Oh, well I guess one thing triggers another thing. But when I first joined Basie's band, we were just doing little one nighters and so forth. Then we started doing tours with Billy Eckstine and Ruth Brown. Speaking of pranksters, Billy Eckstine was a major prankster. I guess Dizzy was in his band too, I guess that's where a lot of that stuff came from. We were playing a state-of-the art hall in Richmond, Virginia. And do you know what a whoopy cushion is?

MW: Yeah.

BP: Billy Eckstine put one under the pillow that Basie sat on. So when he sat down — oh, can you imagine that man? You know people would say, because, actually, musicians can become like little — we all have little boys left around in us. We all, Dizzy Gillespie

certainly was one. Boy I guess I'm going through a lot of stories. One brings on another one. Dizzy Gillespie one time we were in Perugia, Italy and about two o'clock in the afternoon, we had come in to the town and we were going out to get some lunch or something. There was a man in the lobby with a puppet on a string. And he was doing nice little things, making the puppet do a lot of stuff. Anyway, Dizzy Gillespie got interested in this thing, so this was about two or three o'clock in the afternoon. And I think he bought it from this guy. So Dizzy Gillespie, with his creative mind, played with the thing the rest of the evening. So about two o'clock in the morning when we were all coming back, we're sitting around having some wine and stuff, he had that puppet doing everything but talking. It was amazing what a creative mind, because he had that, man he made him jump into your pocket or something. Oh, man, but I always saw that quality about him and Basie and Duke Ellington. They were always curious. What's this? What's that? How does that work?

MW: Let me ask you a couple of questions about that. Do you think that in jazz education today that we're missing something because there aren't these funny little things that find their way into the music?

BP: Definitely.

MW: Give us an example or, or elaborate on that.

BP: Okay. Bands, one of the main ingredients they're missing, I play with some bands and I guess I shouldn't name names. But we do maybe the 1940s Ellington book and so forth. We re-create that. The main ingredient that's missing is fun. They don't realize that those guys had fun. Those guys aren't sitting up here analyzing every note and there's a leading scholar now who conducts bands, and he explains an eighth note to you. That's not necessary. There is a natural quality to the music. The music almost dictates to you how it should be played, if you let it. If you want to analyze it and put all of that, it comes out some very cold music because it doesn't flow from a natural source.

MW: I want to ask you a question and come in on that from another little angle here. And that is this. You know I believe that jazz is a manifestation of oral culture. And can you give us your concept of what you feel music is when it emanates from oral culture or draw us any dichotomies or parallels or differences between oral culture and literate culture. Because I feel like in much of today's jazz education it's too dominated by literate culture. By textbooks.

BP: Right. Yes. A jazz solo should be like a flow of conversation. If I would say to you, "You're dressed nicely today" that's an original statement. You've got on a nice white shirt and then the rest of the solo flows. You make a statement, and then reiterate that statement from the kind of jazz I come from. There is another kind of jazz that sounds like mathematics. It sounds like guys just playing patterns. And that's what he's doing a

lot of times because when you get concerned with the blues scale and all of that, first of all, before you dealt with the blues scale you just find out what the blues is. I never did know whether that was plural or singular. The blues. That doesn't sound right. You know I really, this is a favorite pastime for me. I love talking about jazz because a lot of the things that you're bringing up I do feel are missing from jazz now. And unless people will talk about that and put that back in — when I first joined Randy Weston 15 years ago, he said something that impressed me then and made me understand him. He said, "BP," most people who like me call me BP, he said, "I'm just trying to put the magic back in music." And boy can he ever do it. He is a spellbinder. Every gig I've played with him has been a whole total experience. He has put the magic back in, I'll tell you. We're going to do a show for BET next August, the 8th I think. I really hope so. Because for me, I feel I'm extremely fortunate — working with Count Basie's band, and I've had an amazing career, if I do say so myself. Because for one thing, it's been interesting to me. I've really loved every second of it. But after having played with Lionel Hampton, that was my first entrance into it, then Count Basie. I recorded a little with Duke Ellington. Then I did the Merv Griffin Show for ten years. I did Broadway. I just did the whole gamut. So I thought by now, on the graph of things, I'd be at the peak and on the downward side. But amazingly enough, it seems like it just keeps going up. And I'm more amazed than anybody. Because Randy Weston for an instance, he's just like Count Basie, I can't say only better. I guess well the difference is Count Basie is dead and he's alive you know. But still he's a man who leads by example first of all. And then for me, it's the greatest platform I've ever had just playing with bands. Big bands are nice. You get a little eight bar solo here or a little twelve bar. I think I was known for the bridge I played in "April in Paris" because "April in Paris" became a hit and I had the solo, I don't know it must be eight bars. In big bands that's all I got a chance to play sometimes. I knew I was going to get a chance to play that solo. But now with this group, there's only, for the most part, basically five pieces. Two horns out front. So I get a chance to blow until I'm blue in the face. And a lot of it is music I've created myself because when I first joined his band there wasn't really that much written music. I had to listen to some records and sometimes ask, "What note goes here?" He'd say, "I don't know, find a pretty one and play it."

MW: I want to ask you something. Now for some people that type of guidance is too loose. For other people that's exactly what they want.

BP: Well he knows what he's got. He knows he couldn't say that to anybody you know. So I feel like I am chosen by him and, to make matters better, he pays very well. If he can't — he performs in all configurations, from solo to symphony. So sometimes, a lot of times he'll perform with just himself, an alto player Talib Kibwe, and an African percussionist.

And he performs all over the world, Venezuela, and, but, if the budget can afford to pay me decently, then I'm added. I'm like the fifth member I think that's added to the band. But if he can't pay what he'd like to pay, he just won't hire you. This is good. I like it. So I know whenever he calls it's a well paying gig and no nonsense.

MW: That's another thing I wanted to ask you about. The concept, the difference between, as we know it today with pop culture, the difference between an artist and an entertainer. Because when I look at some of the earlier great jazz musicians, to me they were both. What they did it was art, it was beautiful, it was so beautifully constructed, and yet it was entertaining. And now it seems like we have entertainers that get paid exorbitant amounts of money to sing or play about things that don't have much merit. There is so much raunchiness in today's music. And to me jazz is a more beautiful form of expression that runs closer to the authenticity of art. Could you talk about that for a moment? Well contrast or compare some of your own experiences.

BP: Well it's a little more sophisticated. And I think lazy people don't like jazz because they don't want to take the time to really find out anything about it. How can I address that? Well it made me think of one thing, and I'll come back to your question. But one time I had to deal with sidemen versus artists. Or getting sidemen to look at themselves like artists. Sidemen might be just a person like myself. I was in a big band and I got a chance to play solos here and there. I became aware of the difference between an artist and a sideman when I began, I was a panelist for the National Endowment for the Arts. First of all I was aware this was not the National Endowment for the Sidemen. It was the National Endowment for the Arts. So in order to be funded by it, it's to fund artists. So you have to look at yourself as an artist. And then really go to a dictionary and find out what an artist really is if you don't know. And that's what I would suggest because that's one of those words kind of thrown around you know. Everybody's an artist. You know you draw scratches on the sidewalk and you're an artist. Anyway, I define artist, the way I defined artist was it's a person who shows responsibility, you have a responsibility to act like an artist if you're going to be an artist. And then you have to find out who do you think is an artist. And check out their behavior and so forth. And I don't know, if you said an artist is Sammy Davis Jr. Check to see his demeanor and manner. You don't hear him cursing in front of people.

MW: You know Madonna was signed to a contract for 60 million dollars here about a year ago. And I don't begrudge people their success, but I, when, you know I've won some cultural grants. And whenever I won a grant, at the end of the grant period I have to fill out all these things about how I spent the money and what I did and how it helped the community and what kind of people it reached and who I hired. I have to account for every dollar. You know what I mean? And I would just like to see there be some sense of

accountability if people are going to be paid that much money, what are they actually doing, giving back to a community? You know what I mean? And we'll kind of pick up there. We were talking about the concept of being an artist, and how that can be consistent with, but not always the same as an entertainer. To entertain can merely mean to hold your interest. And that can be done through very positive means or very macabre or very sensational means that don't have a lot to do with the craft of your art.

BP: Well, when you talk about entertainers we have to sort of put in some kind of parameters. What kind of an entertainer are we talking about? Are we talking about Barbra Streisand? Frank Sinatra or Tony Bennett? Because there is that kind of entertainer and then there's other entertainers. There's Victor Borge and stuff. We're still, okay, now, I think you spoke of some commitment to community as well.

MW: Yes.

BP: Well I think those, to me I don't really worry about that too much. Those who see the validity in it will give something back. There is such an ego trip in all of this, until it's very easy to get busy with yourself and forget about all others. Maybe for some people it might be the first time they have been able to enjoy some things. Other people might just be power hungry. I think once you start delving with those millions and millions I think that is a power thing because let's face it, how much do you really need to live on? Having 30 billion dollars, to me, well it's according to your own philosophy and how you look at it you know. I would like to be able to do more myself for various charitable things. And I'd like to see more people into that. But I don't think, I just think some people are going to adhere to that, some are not. Personally I hope by the time I die I can leave something. I'd like to leave some kind of study grant or, preferably, I would like to be part of putting something together that would be here after I'm gone. A jazz class. Or something that would carry, something with some monetary value too because I know money is needed to run things. So I don't know what it's eventually going to be, but you know, I take my part in various things, you know I work on the National Endowment, I have done — sometimes I'm a panelist for the New York State Arts Council, and I call myself a "jazz activist." Because I like to make people aware of jazz wherever. And I'm capable of it since I am, I guess well kind of a lecturer now. I've done a program in the public schools for at least 30 years called "The Story of Jazz." It's a lecture-demonstration where I trace the origin of jazz from the spirituals up to the present day and stuff. And I break it down very basically. When I go into the classroom, I have a participation thing that I go in and I guess I would talk about it now because I would like to see other people use this. When I go into an auditorium, I'll ask how many like jazz with a show of hands, and most of them will raise their hands. And I'll say thank you, put your hands down. Now I'd like you to be truthful with this next question for me. How

many of you don't like jazz? And some of them will kind of sheepishly raise their hands. And I'll say well that's fine. The reason for us being here today, we think people don't know enough about jazz or how it pertains to them. So that's why we're here, to give some information as to how it got started and what it's made of. And I go on to say that if you were to ask me to break it down to its simplest ingredients or a common denominator if you will, I'd say it's made of two things. One is rhythm — or the what? You know and they'll say — uh— and then finally somebody'll say, "The beat." And I'll say yes, that's it. Now we relate to rhythm because we all have a beat. Without it we'd be dead. Where is the beat? Your heartbeat. Okay. So that's why we respond to it. Now when you hear jazz music played by good musicians, it'll make you feel something, because the music is deep feeling. It'll make you feel happy if you're playing an up tune, or it will make you feel sad. So there's two sides of jazz, the happy side of jazz, swing music, bebop and all that; or the sad side, the blues side. And I'll say the blues is a song about a person, a place, or sometimes a consequence. I'll say the first consequence that black people know of in America was slavery. So I go on to talk about if you had to work all day and stuff, you'd have the blues too you know.

MW: Let me ask you a question here. You said the music has a happy side to it and it has a somber side to it. Can it have both at the same time?

BP: Yes if you write it that way. You know, well "Rhapsody in Blue" is not a jazz tune, but that sort of has a well, you know the suites, you can write a suite of tunes. But for the most part, it's either one or the other. It's either a blues tune, a song about I shot my baby, my baby's gone, or my baby ain't got no hair, or something. It's a story about a thing. So back to the story of the consequence. The first blues that we knew was Negro spirituals. "Nobody Knows the Trouble I've Seen." That's a blues. It's as blue as anything you ever heard. That's what most blues are about, everybody's troubles. So I'll do that, and then my band, we play "Nobody Knows—" and the band's still playing behind me, and I'll talk about life under slavery. And I usually say that I don't know what slavery is like. I'm standing up here in an Italian suit and with my gold rings on and stuff, so you know I'm a long way from a slave, but in order to know my history I went to the library to read books about it. And there was one book that I related to. There was one instance in a book that I related to. And I'll say you know slaves aren't supposed to learn to read or write, yet there was one man born in slavery who became so proficient at it until he became editor of a newspaper and that was Frederick Douglass. Now see in his book he said at one time, he had a chance to see his, he only got a chance to see his mother seldom in his life. And he had to walk 20 miles in darkness each time. So I said well for me, how I relate to that is my dad died when I was seven so my mother was my mentor. And every time I needed to know something I'd go and my mother would tell

me. I even went and said can I go traveling on the road at 16. And she was always there for me. So I said slavery for me would have been not to have access to my mother or freedom or anything. But I really would relate to that part of it.

MW: Let me ask you this. I want you to come in on this. That is I know I feel this, is that when I listen to Gospel music or I listen to rhythm & blues or I listen to jazz, even though I do enjoy the music tremendously, it seems to go to someplace inside of me deeper than that because the music for me is need based. Actually if I were to spend a year without hearing any jazz, no R&B and no Gospel, I think I'd become ill.

BP: That's why I didn't ever move to Europe like an expatriate. I kept on wanting to move to Europe, you know like Benny Bailey and Art Farmer and a lot of those guys did. And I kept procrastinating. Finally I got a chance, I played "Ain't Misbehavin'." I lived in Paris for eight months. But I checked myself, and I wondered why I didn't do it. But it was the same thing. If I woke up hearing [scats] I need to hear some B.B. King. I need to hear some Aretha Franklin. Some Stevie Wonder. Some Dizzy Gillespie and John Coltrane. And if I did that for a year, I don't think I would have been the same. I believe my playing would have suffered first, but that's the same point that you have.

MW: The thing is you talk about the aspects of slavery and that was an aspect of denial or deprivation or the stopping you from getting to specific resources that you needed. One you said was if you were thinking in terms of your mother. You were thinking of this person who is a resource for you, who basically in African society took the place of a griot. And so she was your source of knowledge and a source of inspiration and motivation. And so I personally feel that when I'm deprived of something, I use the one thing I do have to try and better my scenario. That's my musical gift, which makes me play out stronger in a way that's more authentic than just because I knew the scale out of that textbook. You see what I mean? I wanted to ask you, we're going to kind of wrap up our interview here, if you have any specific things you'd like to say in closing about jazz education or that you mentioned you'd like to leave something behind to young people. Could you leave us with a statement to inspire or guide young musicians today?

BP: Well there are a couple of things. First of all, I would like to have America realize the validity of jazz. Jazz is an art form. And when I go into schools, I'll ask what are other art forms? Painting. Symphonic music. Ballet. Many things. But all of them started somewhere else. Another continent. Jazz started right here in America. So as Americans, we should all know something about jazz and be proud of it. On the prejudice side, I don't think, I personally don't think white America has ever given black America any credit for anything en masse. George Washington Carver and Martin Luther King and all of that, that's getting credibility. But black people started jazz. We've never been given credit for it. In fact, it has hurt jazz because it was started by black people. Had it been

started by white people I think it would have had a much easier road. I'd like to see America finally say yes, the black man did create a culture that has spread all over the world. Everybody enjoys it now, but it is a black creation. I think that would help a lot of, nothing like that has ever been done, therefore we still have the same old racial problems over and over, over and over. And you keep on asking people, well Negro, what do you want? I say I just want you to recognize me. Recognize that I'm someone. Well black man what do you want? I just want you to recognize me and stuff. Well Nigger what you want? I just want you to recognize me and stuff. It's all the same. But America keeps on right now with the Affirmative Action and all of that. They can't set stuff backwards. The Divine Law is not going to let it go backwards. Anyway that's getting off from — for young people I'd say whatever you do, find something that you honestly like to do. And then it will become a strong force in your life. Right now I'm a dialysis patient. I have to go for dialysis three times a week because I don't have proper kidney function. My kidneys don't function. I would perhaps like to get a transplant sometime, but being a musician has been therapeutic for me. When I'm playing I'm well. Nothing is wrong with me. And I'm fortunate enough to still play strong and still keep my notch, whatever I've carved, on the world class level. I think I'm one of the ten kind of recognized trombone players in the world. I'm fortunate that the creator has given me enough strength to be able to maintain this. So if, whatever it is that you go into, if it's something that you like doing, at some point in your life it may become therapeutic for you, just as music is therapeutic for me. It's as healing for me as any of the medicines I ever take. So I guess it's do something that you really like to do. Find something that you really — don't make your life's work something that you hate.

MW: One person said if you do something that you love, you technically never have to work another day in your life, 'cause it's a love affair.

BP: Yeah. Right. I don't, just like dialysis for me. I've never had a nine to five in my life. When my kidneys broke down, and I had to start dialysis that was maybe about three or four years ago, no it must have been maybe a little before that. At any rate, what I did, I go to the hospital three times a week, three and a half hours. I made this my nine to five. And there are days when I feel like I don't want to go and stuff. This is like, you realize you've got to go to work, I realize I've got to do this, so it doesn't even interfere with my life. I go and do that, and in fact I do it all over the world. I was dialyzed in East Germany. It's become an adventure. So, but the main thing is, be happy.

MW: I would like to just say as we close here, that these interviews with some of the greatest living jazz musicians there are, have come about particularly to rectify some of the injustices that have been done to African American musicians. And I would like to see that taken care of. And I would like to see people get their due. And when I was asked to

participate on these particular interviews, someone asked me about that. And I broke down in tears and I said these people need their respect. And so I believe and I trust that even as we are looking into this camera right now, you are getting some that you richly deserve.

BP: Oh, well, I'll tell you, the fact that you allowed me to be able to voice it, means that it's possible to change. If I didn't get a chance to voice it, nobody would get a chance to see it. Certainly that's just my idea and maybe I could walk around a bitter old man that nobody wanted. But once you put an idea out there, and especially in an institution of learning, there's no telling where that idea can go because that's why I guess when we all do these interviews, we try to do them as purely as possible, and give as honest answers—well we all know how to be politicians, but we hope that we can really impart some of our true feelings. And you have given me the opportunity to do that so I thank you for it.

MW: And thank you. And that concludes our interview with Benny Powell.